



Understanding Depression

What it is, how it feels, and what you can do about it

What Is Depression?

Depression is a common and treatable medical condition that affects how you feel, think, and handle daily activities. It is much more than feeling sad or having a bad day. Depression changes how your brain works, making even simple tasks feel overwhelming. With the right help, most people with depression get better.

Common Symptoms

Emotional:

- Persistent sadness, emptiness, or hopelessness
- Loss of interest in activities you used to enjoy
- Feelings of worthlessness or excessive guilt
- Irritability, even over small things

Physical:

- Changes in appetite or weight
- Sleep problems (too much or too little)
- Fatigue or loss of energy
- Unexplained aches, pains, or headaches

Behavioral and Cognitive:

- Withdrawing from friends, family, or activities
- Trouble concentrating, remembering, or making decisions
- Negative thought patterns or harsh self-criticism
- Thoughts of death or suicide

Depression Is NOT...

✗ "Just laziness."

✓ Depression drains your energy and motivation. Struggling to function is a symptom, not a character flaw.

✗ "A sign of weakness."

✓ Depression affects people of all backgrounds and strengths. Asking for help takes courage.

✗ "Something you can snap out of."

✓ Depression is a medical condition involving brain chemistry — like diabetes or heart disease.

✗ "Your fault."

✓ You did not choose this. Depression has biological, genetic, and environmental causes.

What Causes Depression?

Depression usually results from a combination of factors:

- **Brain chemistry:** Imbalances in neurotransmitters that regulate mood
- **Genetics:** Depression can run in families, though family history doesn't guarantee it
- **Life events:** Loss, trauma, major changes, chronic stress, or difficult relationships
- **Medical conditions:** Chronic illness, hormonal changes, or certain medications

Treatment Works

Depression is one of the most treatable mental health conditions — about 80–90% of people respond to treatment:

- **Talk therapy:** Work with a therapist to build coping skills and change unhelpful thinking (CBT, interpersonal therapy)
- **Medication:** Antidepressants help correct brain chemistry imbalances; they are not addictive
- **Lifestyle changes:** Exercise, sleep hygiene, nutrition, and social connection support recovery
- **Combination:** Many people benefit most from therapy and medication together

What You Can Do Today

1. **Move your body** — Even a 10-minute walk can boost your mood. Start small.
2. **Reach out to one person** — Tell someone you trust how you're feeling.
3. **Keep a simple routine** — Structure helps when everything feels overwhelming.
4. **Limit alcohol and substances** — These can worsen depression even when they feel helpful.
5. **Be kind to yourself** — Talk to yourself as you would a good friend. Recovery takes time.

When to Seek Help

If you or someone you know is in crisis, please reach out:

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline	Call or text 988 (24/7)
Crisis Text Line	Text HOME to 741741
Emergency Services	Call 911
SAMHSA Helpline	1-800-662-4357 (free, 24/7)

You don't have to face this alone. Help is available and recovery is possible.